Chapter Twenty-Six

Education and Health Policies Not Best Suited for Economy

Education

India's Education Policies Have Addressed Mostly Quantitative Aspects

India laid emphasis on higher education in the first twenty years after Independence. Primary education was neglected. It led to the production of well-educated persons from institutions of higher learning, many of whom went abroad. The general masses remained by and large uneducated.

India promulgated its first Education Policy in 1968, followed by the second in 1986. Both these policies laid emphasis on compulsory school education and spread of literacy. The Government of India also initiated several path-breaking programmes. By the turn of the century, almost every eligible child was in school and the 'gross enrolment ratio'—the ratio of students in elementary schools to the number of students in the age group of six to fourteen—crossed 100 per cent. Literacy also spread. Most states were declared as fully literate.

Thereafter, universal enrolment for secondary education and creation of government school infrastructure became the major policy objective. Secondary school gross enrolment ratio rose to a high level of about 75 per cent by 2015. It remains at that level, as per World Bank data.

The gross enrolment ratio was achieved by constructing schools, appointing teachers and bringing students to schools with no charge for